The World View

Laws regulating facial coverings in general and *hijab*s, *niqab*s and *burqa*s in particular vary vastly across nations. Many western countries have in recent years passed legislation to ban such clothing in public areas; in many Islamic countries, they are not a legal requirement but a cultural expectation

WESTERN WORLD



FRANCE

Beginning April 11, 2011, clothing that covered the face, including *niqab*s and *burqa*s, was banned in public areas. *Hijab*s were exempt as they leave the face uncovered

BELGIUM

Belgium too banned the wearing of *niqab*s or other face coverings in 2011 on the grounds of security, arguing that they made policing much more difficult

SWITZERLAND

In 2021, over 51 per cent of Swiss voters were in favour of a referendum to ban the wearing of *niqab*s or *burqa*s in public places like roads, shops and restaurants

AUSTRIA

In 2017, Austria banned the use of full facial veils in public places like universities, on public transport and in government buildings like courthouses

UNITED STATES

In 1837, the US Congress had banned all forms of head-wear being worn in the house during sessions. In 2019, this was partially repealed to permit religious clothing, after the election of Congresswoman Ilhan Omar



AUSTRALIA

Though there is debate over whether *niqab*s and *burqa*s should be banned in public places, in 2021, Australia released a stamp honouring frontline Covid warriors, including a doctor in a *hijab*

NEW ZEALAND

In 2020, the New Zealand police updated its uniform to include a *hijab*, in an effort to attract more Muslim women



ISLAMIC NATIONS

SAUDI ARABIA

Though *hijab*s, *niqab*s and *burqa*s are very common in Saudi Arabia, in 2018, crown prince Mohammed bin Salman said the only Islamic requirement was that women wear 'decent, respectful clothing'

IRAN

The *hijab* has been compulsory for women since the Iranian Revolution in 1979. Reportedly, a law passed in 1995 allows authorities to jail women for up to 60 days if found without a veil in public

PAKISTAN

In 2019, authorities in Peshawar and Hamirpur reportedly directed educational institutions to ensure all female students wore *abaya*s. After protests, this was revoked

INDONESIA

In 2021, Indonesia banned public schools from enforcing religious dress codes, after it was revealed that some non-Muslim students and teachers were being forced to wear *hijab*s

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORY